Living With High Prices in Rural Virginia

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In Tappahannock, Virginia, a cafe called Java Jacks sells coffee and pastries under the slogan "Come in, We're Awesome." Owner Jeans Owens and her husband took over about eight years ago. Their first years brought the pandemic and rising prices.

Coffee prices at the cafe are up more than 30 percent since 2022. A takeout box that once cost 12 cents now costs nearly 30 cents, and a cup with lid and straw that once cost 3 cents now costs more than 20 cents. The electricity bill has jumped from about $450 or $500 a month to more than $1,000.

Owens works hard to keep menu prices affordable, holding some meals at $10. She buys milk and juice at Walmart instead of from a supplier, picks up fruit locally, and compares three **suppliers**, switching to the cheapest. More senior citizens now share orders, and tips dipped when gas prices rose.

Finding and keeping staff is her biggest stress. Her second coffee spot, across the river in Warsaw, has also been short-staffed for months at a time. Rents have risen where the **median** income is around $50,000 a year, so Owens has helped workers find housing, put some up in a motel, and **carpools** five employees to work.

Jameka Campbell works two jobs while raising two children. She manages an office at Menokin and works for a nonprofit teaching people to grow fresh food. She stretches her budget with Walgreens **coupon** deals, aiming to spend $100 a month on household supplies. On one trip she spent $60.04 and saved $27.71, enough, she said, for a meal or a quarter tank of gas. "I'm not rich. I'm not poor. I'm in between," she said. Owens, running for the town's **non-partisan** council, says whoever wins the district's tight race should know: "We're struggling."

Word Treasure

median -- The middle value, so half of people earn more and half earn less.
suppliers -- Businesses that sell goods to a shop or cafe.
carpools -- Sharing rides to work in one car.
non-partisan -- Not tied to any political party.
coupon -- A ticket or code that gives you money off something you buy.

Background you need

Inflation means prices for everyday things rise over time, so the same money buys less.

Small businesses must pay for ingredients, packaging, electricity and workers, and when those costs rise they may raise menu prices or find cheaper suppliers.

Coupons and sales help shoppers spend less by cutting the price of household goods.

In rural areas, fewer buses and higher rents can make it harder for workers to find housing and get to work.

Break it down

LEAD: Living with high prices in rural Virginia
KEY EVENT: Java Jacks faces rising costs
+- WHO: Jeans Owens, cafe owner
+- WHAT: Coffee up more than 30 percent, boxes, cups and electricity up too
+- RESPONSE: $10 meals, Walmart milk and juice, comparing suppliers
KEY EVENT: Campbell stretches her budget
+- WHO: Jameka Campbell, two jobs and two children
+- HOW: Walgreens coupons, $100 a month goal
CLOSE: Owens says small businesses are struggling

Why it matters

Rising prices touch every family, and stories like this show how small choices, from coupons to comparing suppliers, help people cope.

Test what you remember

1. What is the name of the cafe in Tappahannock?

(A) Walmart
(B) Menokin
(C) Java Jacks
(D) Warsaw

2. By how much have coffee prices at the cafe risen since 2022?

(A) More than 30 percent
(B) About $1,000 a month
(C) More than 20 cents
(D) 12 cents

3. What does Owens buy at Walmart instead of from a supplier?

(A) Milk and juice
(B) Takeout boxes
(C) Coffee
(D) Fresh fruit

4. About how many employees does Owens carpool to work?

(A) Five
(B) Two
(C) Ten
(D) Three

5. What is Campbell's monthly goal for household supplies?

(A) $27.71
(B) $60.04
(C) $50,000
(D) $100

6. What did Campbell say about her own situation?

(A) We're struggling.
(B) We carpool five employees to work.
(C) Come in, We're Awesome.
(D) I'm not rich. I'm not poor. I'm in between.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Jeans Owens: Rising costs make running a small cafe hard, from ingredients to staffing.

2. Jameka Campbell: Careful coupon deals and research help a working family manage high prices.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):